

iPhone

Your iPhone collects a lot of data by default, including your location, app activity, personal relationships, and advertising identifiers. This guide provides settings and features to help you improve your privacy and security. You don't need to do everything to get some benefit. Focus on the things that make sense for your situation.

Reviewed: May 2026

GENERAL

Automatic updates

CRITICAL

Settings → General → Software Update

Why it matters: An up to date operating system is key to maintaining your phone's security as it ensures security updates are installed right away. The latest versions may block tools like Cellebrite and GrayKey.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **General** → **Software Update** → **Automatic Updates**
2. Toggle on **Automatically Install**
3. Next, open **Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Background Security Improvements**
4. Toggle on **Automatically Install**

Sources: Update iOS on iPhone - Apple (<https://support.apple.com/guide/iphone/update-ios-iph3e504502/ios>)

Turn off public activity

HIGH

Venmo → Me → Settings → Privacy

Why it matters: Turn off your public activity on apps like Venmo. Transactions are public by default. Public activity can be used to tie you to others, like friends and family.

Steps:

1. Open **Venmo** → **Me** → **Settings** → **Privacy**
2. Under **Default Privacy Settings** → change to **Private**
3. Under **More** → **Past Transactions** → **Change All to Private**

Sources: Who Can See What You Do On Venmo? - Consumer Reports (<https://www.consumerreports.org/money/digital-payments/who-can-see-what-you-do-on-venmo-a6906448606/>)

BIOMETRICS & PASSCODE

Use an alphanumeric passcode

CRITICAL

Settings → Face ID & Passcode → Change Passcode

Why it matters: An alphanumeric password (meaning numbers, letters, and special characters) that's 8 or more characters is more secure than a 4 or 6 digit PIN. If possible, aim for a password that's 12 or more characters.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Face ID & Passcode**
2. Tap **Change Passcode** and enter your current passcode
3. Tap **Passcode Options**
4. Select **Custom Alphanumeric Code**
5. Choose a passphrase you can memorize. Aim for 8+ characters

Sources: iPhone User Guide - Apple (<https://support.apple.com/guide/iphone/set-a-passcode-iph14a867ae/ios>)

Restrict biometrics

CRITICAL

Settings → Face ID & Passcode

Why it matters: Best practice is to turn off biometrics completely, however, that advice is not accessible for everyone. Additionally, Advanced Data Protection is unavailable if you do not have biometrics enabled.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Face ID & Passcode**
2. Scroll to **Face ID Attention** → turn on **Require Attention for Face ID**
3. You can temporarily disable biometrics in an emergency by triggering the power-off screen (hold the power + volume button or rapidly press the power button 5 times)

Sources: iPhone User Guide - Apple (<https://support.apple.com/guide/iphone/set-up-face-id-iph6d162927a/26/ios/26>)

Disable Control Center on lock screen

HIGH

Settings → Face ID & Passcode

Why it matters: This setting makes your Control Center inaccessible while your phone is locked. This can prevent someone from putting your phone in airplane mode or disabling cellular data without your consent. They can still turn your phone off, but that's ok.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Face ID & Passcode**
 2. Under **Allow access when locked** → toggle off **Control Center**
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Disable changes to Face ID & Passcode

HIGH

Settings → Screen Time → Content & Privacy Restrictions

Why it matters: This disables the ability to make changes to your Face ID or Passcode and hides the option from your settings. To increase the effectiveness of this setting, you should set a Screen Time passcode and make sure it's different from your iPhone passcode. Note: to make future changes to Face ID & Passcode, you must turn this setting back on.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Screen Time** → **Content & Privacy Restrictions**
 2. Under **Allow Changes to** → change **Passcode & Face ID** to **Don't Allow**
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ICLOUD PROTECTION

Enable 2FA

CRITICAL

Settings → [Your Name] → Sign-In & Security → Two-Factor Authentication

Why it matters: Two-factor authentication can prevent someone from accessing your iCloud account even if they have your password.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **[Your Name]** → **Sign-In & Security** → **Two-Factor Authentication**
 2. Follow the prompts
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Enable Recovery Key

CRITICAL

Settings → [Your Name] → Sign-In & Security → Recovery Key

Why it matters: Allows you to regain access to your account if you lose your login credentials or if your account is taken over. Be sure to save your recovery key somewhere safe like a password manager, and not on your phone or computer.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **[Your Name]** → **Sign-In & Security** → **Recovery Key**
 2. Follow the prompts
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Enable Advanced Data Protection

CRITICAL

Settings → [Your Name] → iCloud → Advanced Data Protection

Why it matters: Advanced Data Protection enables end-to-end encryption for iCloud backups, photos, notes, messages, and more. Only your devices can decrypt the data. Not even Apple can access it. Note that you must have biometrics enabled to turn it on.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **[your name]** → **iCloud**
 2. Open **Advanced Data Protection**
 3. Choose **Turn On Advanced Data Protection** and follow the prompts
 4. Set up an **Account Recovery Contact** or save your **Recovery Key** so you don't lose access to your iCloud
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Enable Find My

HIGH

Settings → [Your Name] → Find My

Why it matters: You can set up Find My to be tracked even if your phone is dead or has been turned off. It will ping the last known location. Setting up Find My also allows you to remotely wipe your iPhone from another device on your account. Note that remote wipe only works if your phone is turned on and connected to cellular or wifi.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **[your name]** → **Find My** → **Find My iPhone**
2. Toggle on **Find My network**
3. Toggle on **Send Last Location**

Sources: Add your iPhone to Find My - Apple (<https://support.apple.com/guide/iphone/add-your-iphone-iph9a847efc7/26/ios/26>)

LOCATION SERVICES

Restrict location services

CRITICAL

Settings → Privacy & Security → Location Services

Why it matters: Location data is actively sold to data brokers and has been purchased by federal agencies including ICE to locate individuals. Most apps have no legitimate need for your location - especially in the background.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Location Services**
 2. For apps that don't need your location (social media, shopping, games), set to **Never**
 3. For apps that occasionally need location (maps, rideshare, food delivery), set to **While Using the App**
 4. Scroll to **System Services** and disable **Location-Based Ads**, **Location-Based Apple Suggestions**, and **Significant Locations**
 5. Also disable **iPhone Analytics** and **Routing & Traffic** if you don't use Apple Maps
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APP TRACKING

Disable cross-app tracking requests

HIGH

Settings → Privacy & Security → Tracking

Why it matters: When Allow Apps to Request to Track is on, apps can ask you to let them track your activity across other apps – feeding your data to ad networks. Turning this off means apps can't even prompt you, and any existing permissions are automatically revoked.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Tracking**
2. Toggle off **Allow Apps to Request to Track**

NOTIFICATIONS

Hide notification previews

HIGH

Settings → Notifications → Show Previews

Why it matters: Push notifications can be tied to your identity. The FBI has been documented requesting push notification records from Apple and push notification data was recently extracted from an iPhone

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Notifications**
2. Tap **Show Previews** at the top and set to **When Unlocked** or **Never**
3. For high-risk apps (Signal, banking, email), open each app in the notifications list and set **Show Previews** to **Never** individually

Sources: FBI has requested push notification records from Apple and Google – Washington Post (<https://www.washingtonpost.com/technology/2024/02/29/push-notification-surveillance-fbi/>)

AIRDROP

Restrict AirDrop to contacts only

MEDIUM

Settings → General → AirDrop

Why it matters: Having AirDrop set to Everyone allows any nearby person to attempt to send you files. While mostly a nuisance risk, it can also be used by bad actors to push malicious content to your device.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **General** → **AirDrop**
2. Select **Contacts Only** for everyday use, or **Receiving Off** when in crowded public spaces

ADVERTISING ID

Reset and disable personalized ads

MEDIUM

Settings → Privacy & Security → Apple Advertising

Why it matters: Your Advertising Identifier (IDFA) is a unique ID tied to your device that ad networks use to track your behavior across apps and build a detailed profile. Disabling personalized ads limits that profiling.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Apple Advertising**
 2. Toggle off **Personalized Ads**
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STOLEN DEVICE PROTECTION

Enable Stolen Device Protection

MEDIUM

Settings → Face ID & Passcode → Stolen Device Protection

Why it matters: Stolen Device Protection adds biometric authentication and a one-hour security delay for sensitive actions when away from familiar locations - preventing a thief who observed your passcode from locking you out of your account.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Face ID & Passcode**
 2. Scroll down and tap **Stolen Device Protection**
 3. Toggle on **Stolen Device Protection**
 4. Under Require Security Delay, consider selecting **Always** for maximum protection
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ADVANCED

Enable security keys for 2FA

HIGH

Settings → [your name] → Sign-In & Security

Why it matters: Security keys are a physical device like YubiKey that act as an additional form of authentication. When configured, your iCloud account cannot be accessed without the physical security key. Note that Apple requires you to configure at least 2 keys in case one is lost.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **[your name]** → **Sign-In & Security** → **Two-Factor Authentication** → **Security Keys**
2. Tap **Add Security Keys**
3. Follow the prompts

Sources: iPhone User Guide - Apple (<https://support.apple.com/guide/iphone/use-security-keys-iph5acc5b28c/ios>)

Lockdown Mode

HIGH

Settings → Privacy & Security → Lockdown Mode

Why it matters: Lockdown Mode is a restrictive setting that can be used in an emergency or when you have reasonable belief that your phone is at risk of being taken. It blocks USB-C connections, prevents biometrics from being used (only after initial reboot), and many other features. You will likely only need this turned on some of the time as it's very restrictive for day-to-day use.

Steps:

1. Open **Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Lockdown Mode** → **Turn On Lockdown Mode**
2. Follow the prompts

Sources: About Lockdown Mode - Apple (<https://support.apple.com/en-us/105120>)

Lockdown Mode shortcut

HIGH

Shortcuts → New Shortcut

Why it matters: Unlike Android, there isn't a built-in shortcut to access Lockdown Mode on iOS. However, it's possible to create one using the iOS Shortcuts feature that's available on most iPhones.

Steps:

1. Open **Shortcuts** → **+** (plus sign)
2. Search for **Open URLs**
3. Tap on **URL** to edit
4. Paste the following: **prefs:root=Privacy&path=LOCKDOWN_MODE** then rename as 'Lockdown'
5. Next, add to your Control Center → swipe down to open Control Center → tap and hold down on the screen until you can edit the widgets
6. Tap **Add a Control** → search for **Shortcuts** → **Run Shortcut** → **Choose** → select the shortcut you created → then exit the prompts

Sources: iPhone User Guide - Apple (<https://support.apple.com/guide/iphone/use-and-customize-control-center-iph59095ec58/ios>)